

Alert 8816 – Blocked Connection to a Malicious Phishing URL

Alert triage, log analysis, and escalation in a simulated SOC environment.

Investigation at a glance	
Alert ID	8816
Alert rule	Access to Blacklisted External URL Blocked by Firewall
Severity	High
Date	23 June 2026
Environment	TryHackMe SOC Simulator (Analyst VM)
Tools used	Splunk, TryDetectThis
Verdict	True Positive — escalated to Level 2

Goal / Objective

A firewall alert (8816) fired in the SOC when a workstation on the internal network tried to reach a URL that was on the company blacklist. The connection was blocked, but a blocked attempt still needs looking into. My job for this investigation was to triage the alert, work out whether it was a real threat or a false alarm, find out what the host was doing and where the link came from, decide whether it could be closed at Level 1 or needed escalating, and write a clear case report that anyone picking it up later could follow.

Tools Used

- Splunk — the SIEM I used to search and read the firewall and email logs.
- TryDetectThis — a URL and IP reputation tool, used to check the destination address.
- TryHackMe SOC Simulator (Analyst VM) — the simulated SOC environment, including the alert queue and the case report system.
- Firewall logs — web-browsing traffic that showed the blocked connection.
- Email logs — used to trace the phishing message that carried the link.

What I Did

1. Picked up Alert 8816 from the queue and read through the alert details to understand what had been flagged.
2. Noted the key fields: the source host, the destination IP, the URL, the port, and the firewall rule that blocked the traffic.

3. Searched the source host (10.20.2.17) in Splunk to see what else that machine had been doing around the same time.
4. Searched the destination IP (67.199.248.11) to check whether the host actually connected or the attempt was stopped.
5. Searched the shortened URL in Splunk, which linked the firewall event back to a phishing email sent to the same user a minute earlier.
6. Ran the destination IP through TryDetectThis to check its reputation.
7. Classified the alert as a True Positive and wrote the case report — timeline, affected entities, reasoning, remediation steps, and indicators.
8. Marked the alert for escalation to Level 2 and submitted it to close out my part of the work.

Investigation Summary

I started by opening Alert 8816 from the queue. It was a High severity firewall alert called “Access to Blacklisted External URL Blocked by Firewall,” raised on 23 June 2026 at around 06:10. The details showed the firewall had blocked an outbound connection: the action was “blocked,” the source was internal host 10.20.2.17 on port 34257, the destination was 67.199.248.11 on port 80, the URL was <http://bit.ly/3sHkX3da12340>, the application was web-browsing, the protocol was TCP, and the rule that caught it was “Blocked Websites.” So the connection had already been stopped — but a machine on the network had tried to reach a blacklisted address, and I wanted to know why.

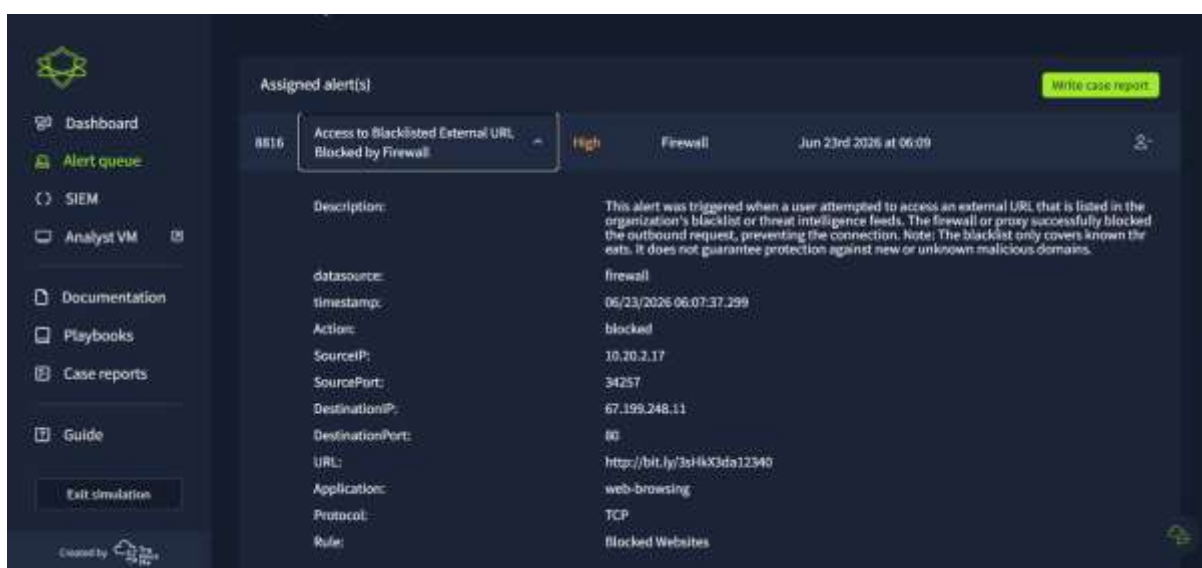


Figure 1 — Alert 8816 in the queue, with the firewall details showing a blocked connection from host 10.20.2.17 to the blacklisted URL.

Checking the source host

My first move was to look at the source host. I searched 10.20.2.17 in Splunk to see what that machine had been up to. The search returned the blocked connection to the bit.ly link at 06:07:37.

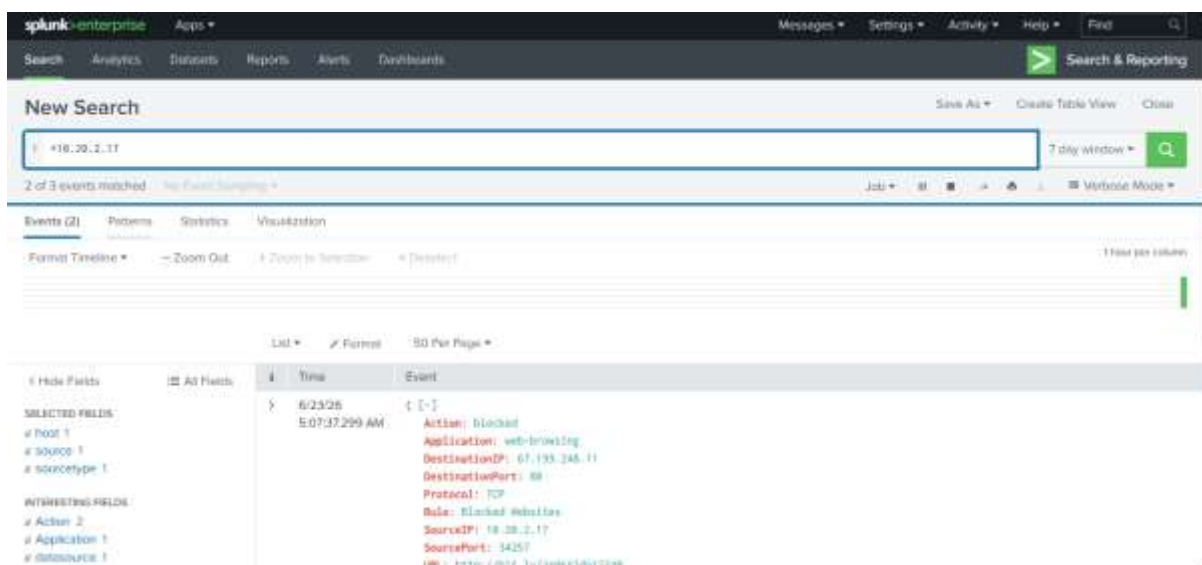


Figure 2 — Searching the source host (10.20.2.17) in Splunk. The blocked connection to the bit.ly link appears in the results.

The same host also had an ordinary allowed connection a couple of minutes earlier — a normal Google search about setting up a payroll system. That looked like routine work browsing, which told me the machine wasn't generally reaching out to bad sites; the blocked connection was the one event that stood out.

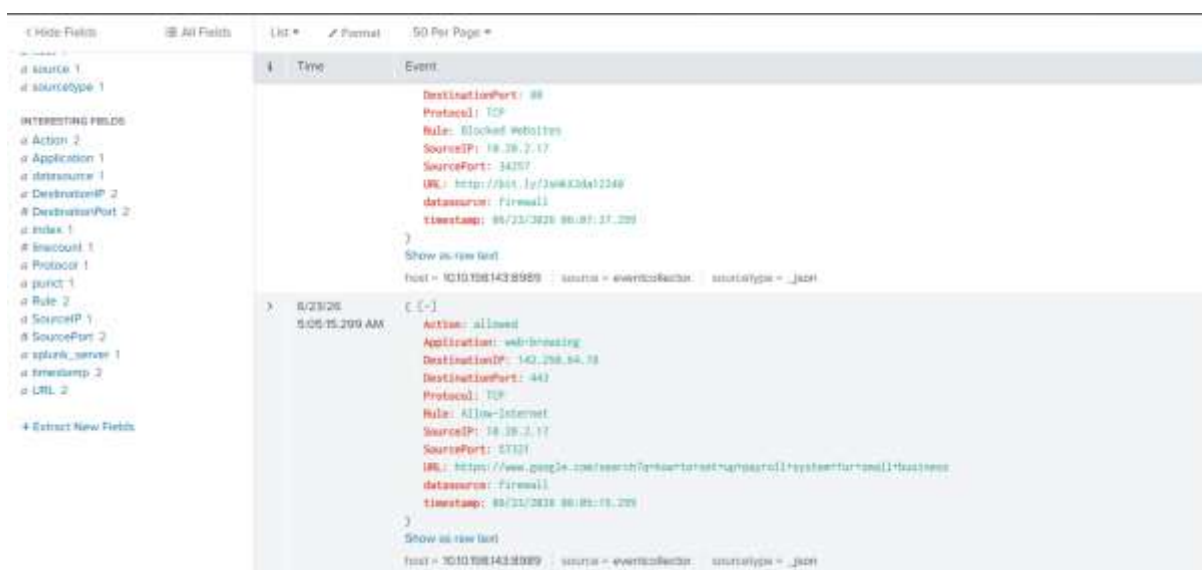


Figure 3 — The same host's other recent traffic: a normal, allowed Google search. Routine activity, which made the blocked connection stand out.

Checking the destination IP

Next I searched the destination IP, 67.199.248.11, to confirm whether the host had actually reached it. Only one event came back.

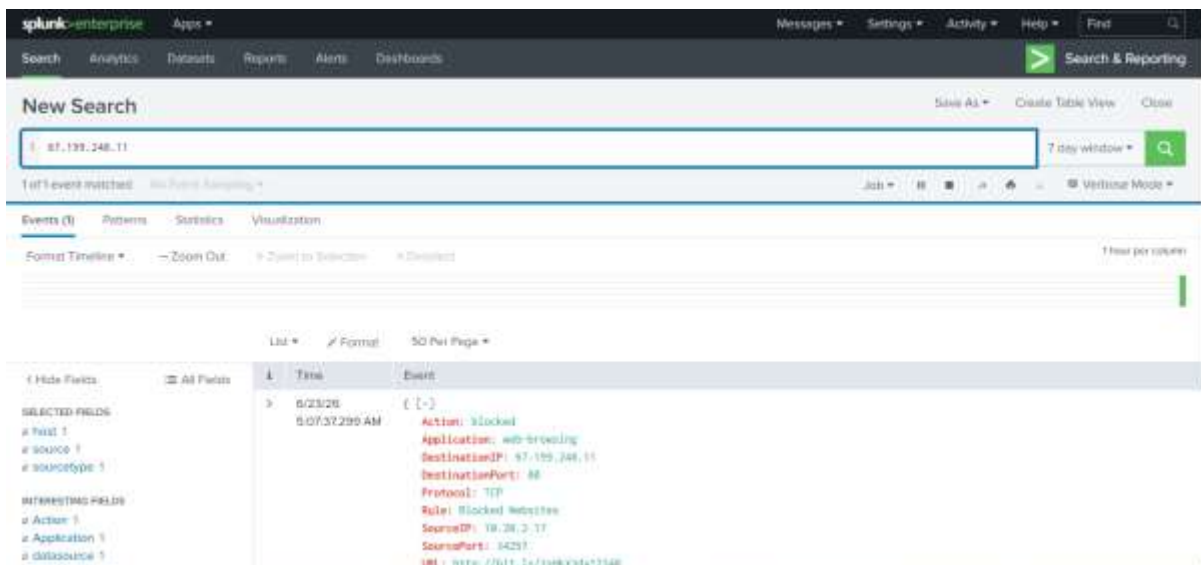


Figure 4 — Searching the destination IP (67.199.248.11) in Splunk returned a single event.

It was the same blocked connection, stopped under the “Blocked Websites” rule. Because there was no successful session to that IP anywhere in the logs, I could be confident the firewall had done its job and nothing got through to that address.

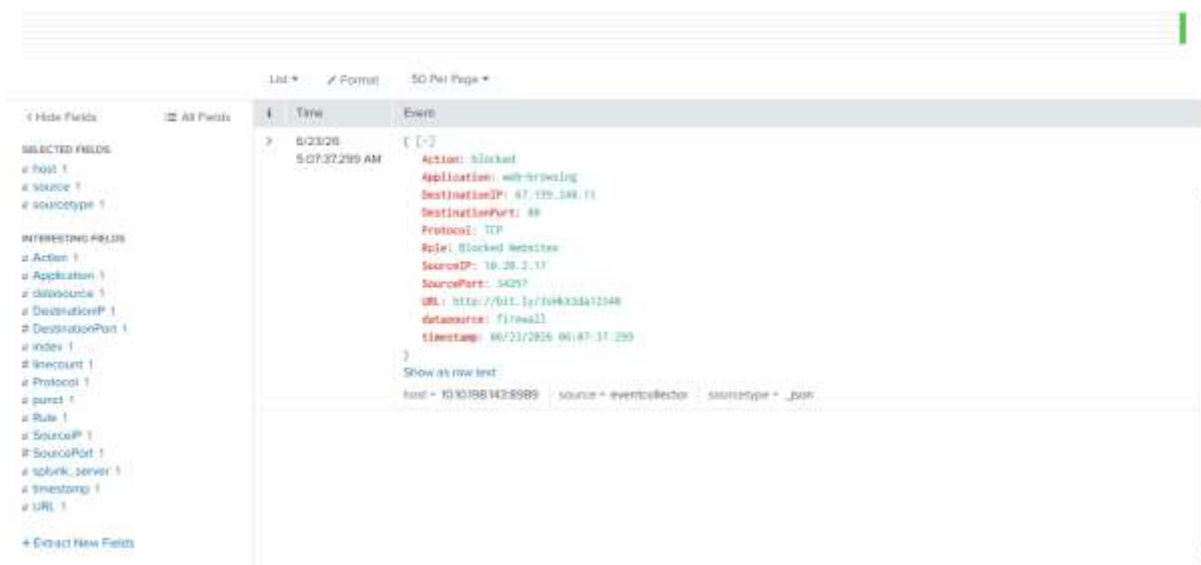


Figure 5 — The full firewall event for the destination IP, blocked under the 'Blocked Websites' rule. No successful session to that IP was found in the logs.

Tracing the URL back to its source

I then searched the shortened URL itself to see where it had come from. This time two events came back.

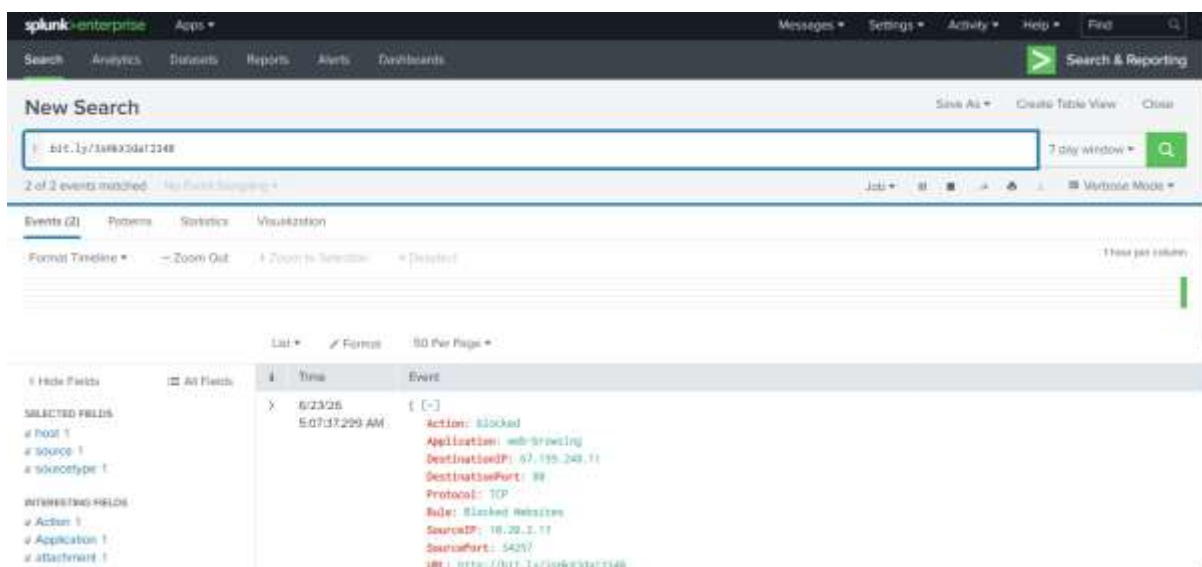


Figure 6 — Searching the shortened URL (bit.ly/3sHkX3da12348) returned two events.

The second event was an inbound email — and it was the source of the link. The message went to h.harris@thetrydaily.thm from urgents@amazon.biz, with the subject “Your Amazon Package Couldn’t Be Delivered - Action Required.” It told the user their package couldn’t be delivered because of an incomplete address and asked them to confirm their shipping details by clicking the link, with a warning that the package would be returned within 48 hours. That is a clear phishing email: the sender is pretending to be Amazon but using a .biz domain, the greeting is a generic “Dear Customer,” it pushes a deadline to make the user act fast, and the real destination is hidden behind a shortened link. The email arrived at 06:06:23 and the firewall blocked the connection to the link at 06:07:37 — about 74 seconds apart. That short gap strongly suggests the user opened the email and clicked the link almost straight away.

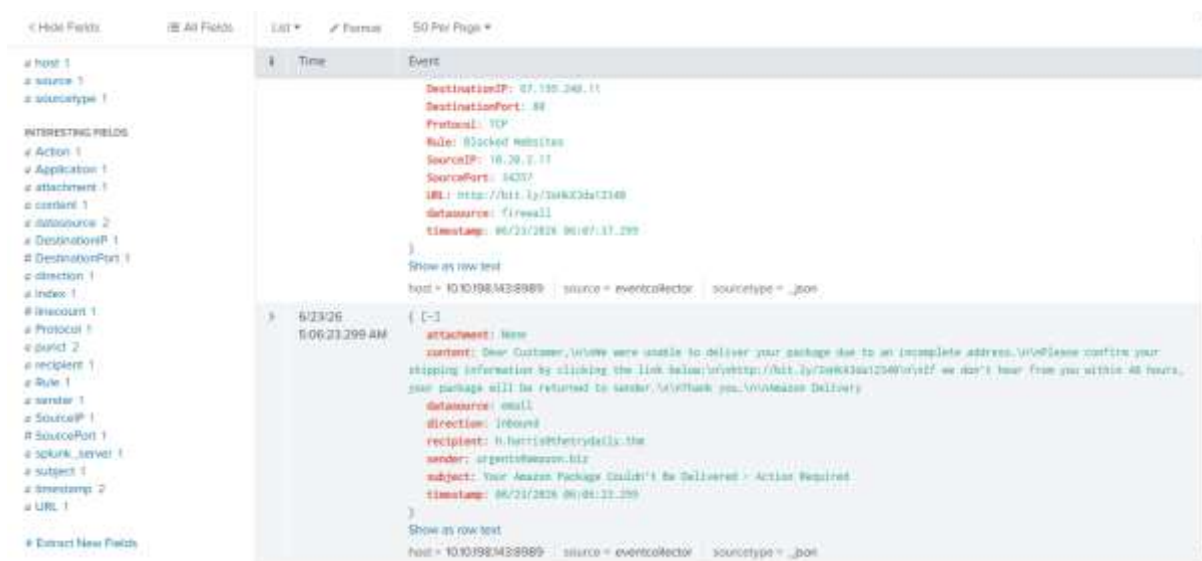


Figure 7 — The second event: the phishing email that carried the link, sent to h.harris@thetrydaily.thm from a fake Amazon address.

Confirming the reputation of the destination

To be sure the link wasn't just suspicious-looking but actually dangerous, I opened TryDetectThis and ran a check on the destination.



Figure 8 — Opening TryDetectThis to check the reputation of the destination.

The result for 67.199.248.11 came back as MALICIOUS. That lined up with everything else and confirmed the host had tried to reach a known-bad address.

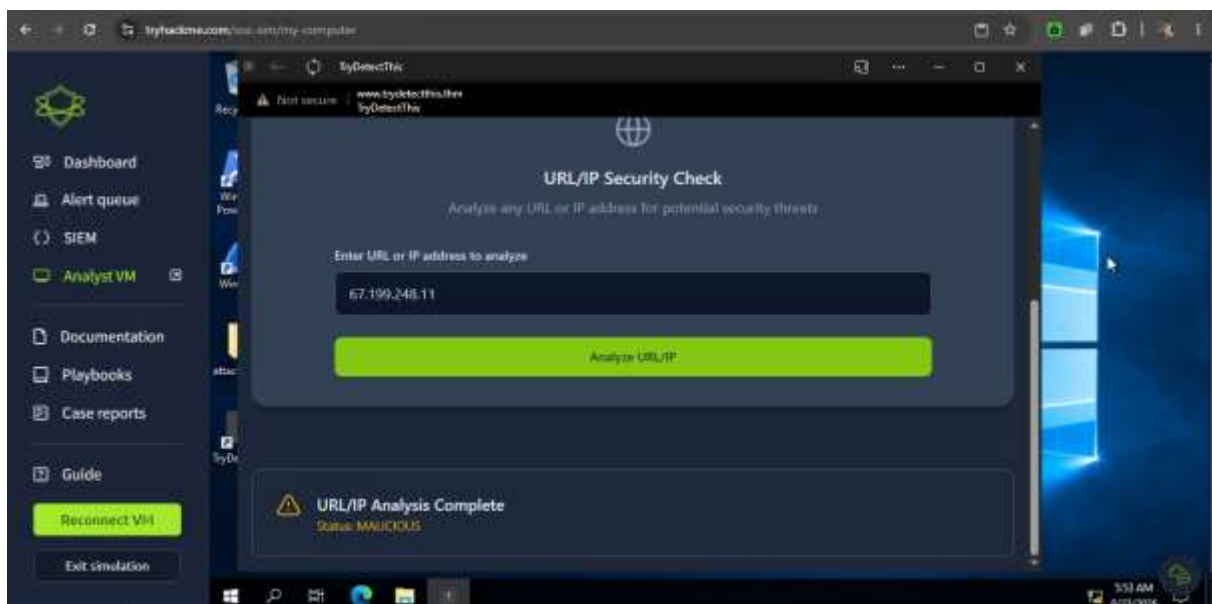


Figure 9 — TryDetectThis result for 67.199.248.11: status MALICIOUS.

Documenting the case and making the call

With the analysis done, I wrote up the case report for event 8816.

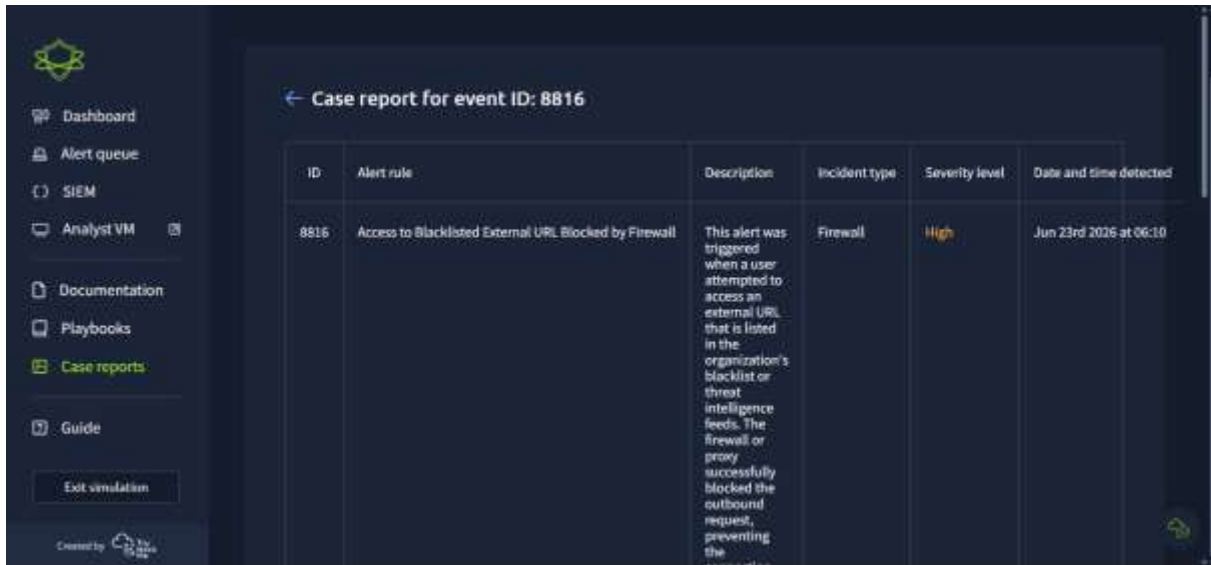


Figure 10 — Starting the case report for event 8816.

I set the incident classification to True Positive, because the evidence showed a real attempt to reach confirmed malicious infrastructure rather than a false alarm.

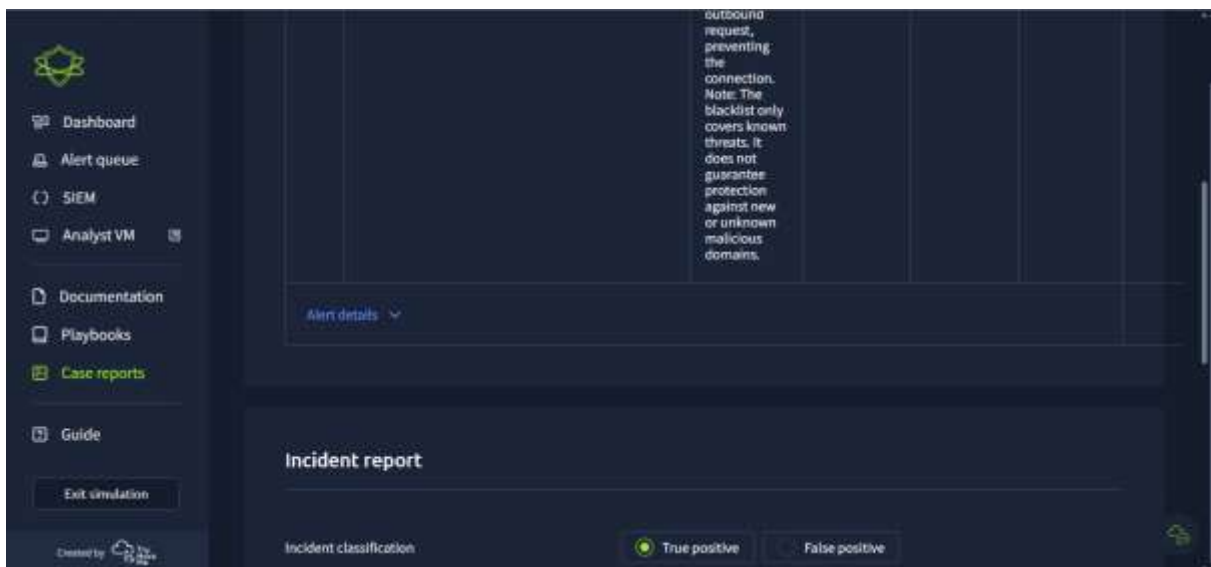


Figure 11 — Setting the incident classification to True Positive.

In the report I recorded the time of activity and the affected entities — the user (Hannah Harris), the source host (10.20.2.17), the malicious URL, and the destination IP and port.



Figure 12 — The case report: time of activity and the list of affected entities.

I explained why I classified it as a True Positive and why it needed escalating: the firewall blocked this attempt, but the blacklist only covers known threats, so it won't catch a new malicious domain the user might click next. The same URL and host were also tied to earlier phishing activity against this user, so the threat wasn't a one-off.

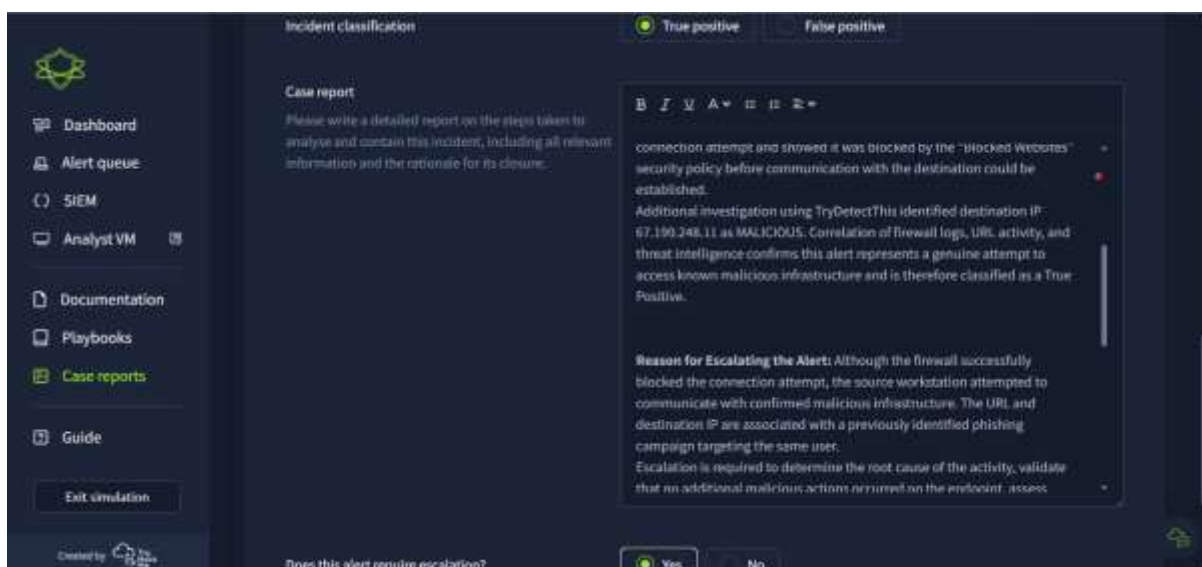


Figure 13 — The case report: reasoning for the True Positive verdict and the escalation.

I then listed the recommended remediation actions — investigating the workstation, checking the endpoint logs, confirming no other machines tried the same link, keeping the URL and IP blocked, searching the mail environment for similar messages, and following up with the user on phishing awareness.

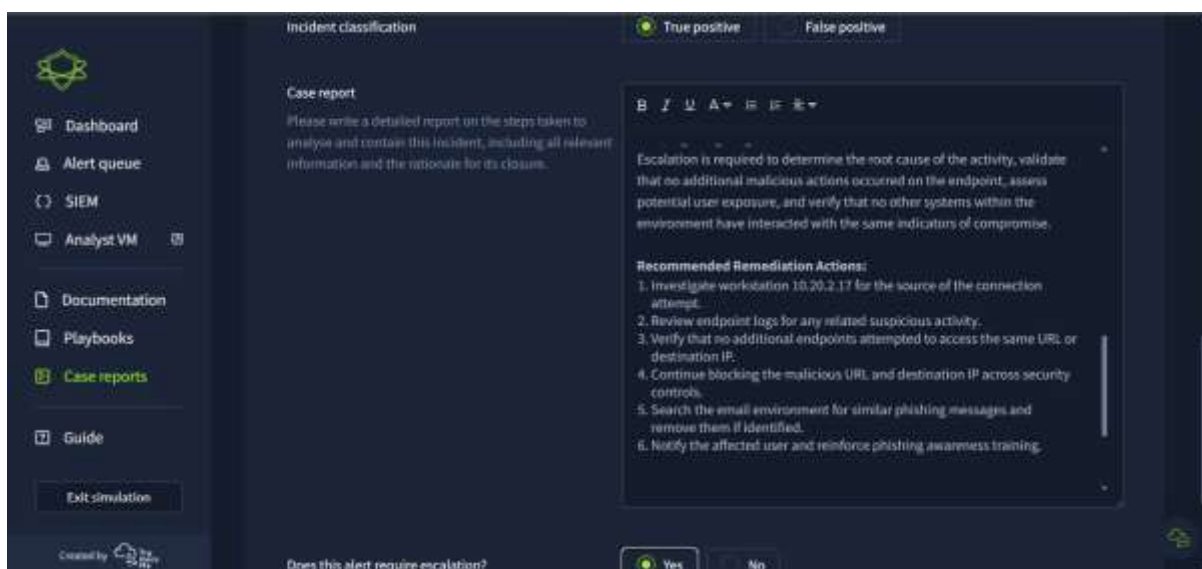


Figure 14 — The case report: escalation reasoning and the recommended remediation actions.

Finally I added the list of attack indicators — the URL, the destination IP, the protocol and port, the firewall rule, and the source host — set escalation to Yes, and submitted to close the alert.

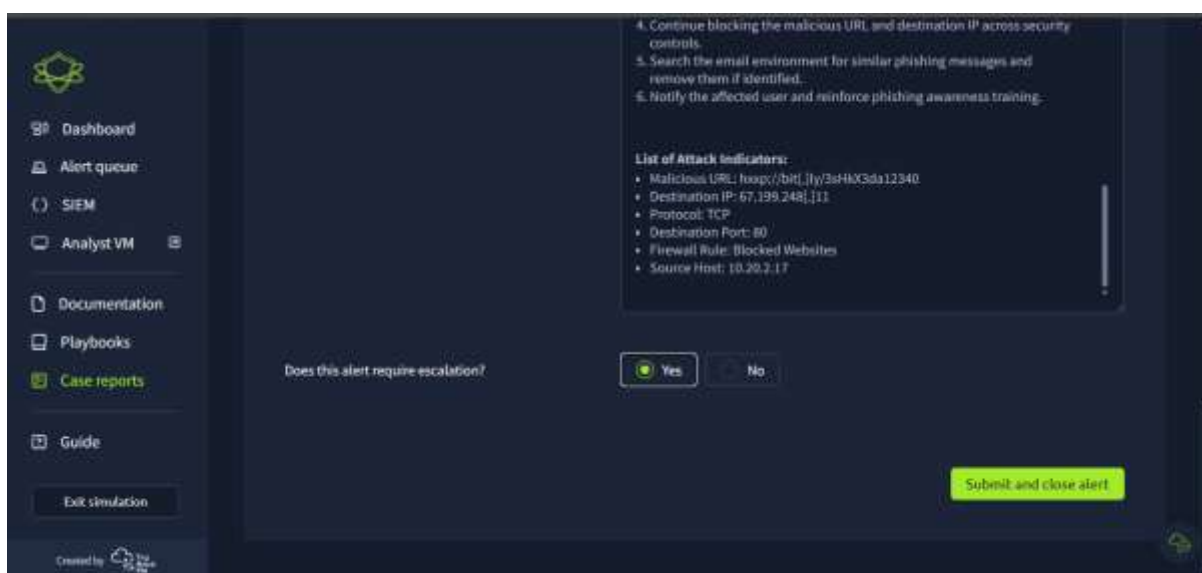


Figure 15 — The case report: attack indicators, escalation set to Yes, ready to submit and close.

I kept the wording of the report careful on one point. The firewall log proves the host attempted the connection and that it was blocked, so I wrote it that way rather than stating outright that the user definitely clicked — even though the 74-second timing points strongly towards a click. It's a small thing, but I wanted the report to say exactly what the evidence supports.

Results / Findings

The investigation confirmed this was a genuine threat, not a false positive. In short:

- A workstation (10.20.2.17) used by Hannah Harris tried to reach a malicious URL (bit.ly/3sHkX3da12340, resolving to 67.199.248.11), and the firewall blocked it under the “Blocked Websites” rule.
- The link came from a phishing email impersonating Amazon, sent to the same user about a minute before the connection attempt.
- TryDetectThis confirmed the destination IP as malicious.
- There was no successful connection to the malicious IP in the logs — the block held.
- I classified the alert as a True Positive and escalated it to Level 2 so the endpoint could be checked and the wider follow-up handled.

Key indicators (IOCs)	
Malicious URL	hxxp://bit[.]ly/3sHkX3da12340
Destination IP	67.199.248[.]11 (TCP/80) — confirmed malicious
Source host	10.20.2.17
Affected user	h.harris@thetrydaily[.]thm
Phishing sender	urgents@amazon[.]biz
Email subject	Your Amazon Package Couldn't Be Delivered - Action Required
Firewall rule	Blocked Websites
Verdict	True Positive — escalated to Level 2

Indicators are defanged, which is standard practice in written reports so the links can't be clicked by accident.

Skills Demonstrated

- Alert triage and prioritisation
- SIEM log analysis with Splunk
- Phishing email analysis (sender, content, and intent)
- Pivoting across multiple data sources (firewall and email logs)
- URL and IP reputation checks / threat intelligence
- Indicator of Compromise (IOC) identification
- Incident classification (true positive vs false positive)
- Escalation decision-making (Level 1 vs Level 2)
- Incident documentation and case report writing
- Evidence-based reasoning and attention to detail

What I Learned

A few things stood out from this one. The biggest was how much a single shortened link can tie separate events together — searching the bit.ly URL is what connected the firewall block to the phishing email and turned a “blocked connection” into a clear phishing story. I also learned not to treat a blocked connection as the end of the job; the firewall stopped this attempt, but the user behaviour and the chance that something else slipped past still matter, which is why it was worth escalating. Checking the host's other activity, rather than just the one flagged event,

helped me judge how serious it really was. And writing the report taught me to be careful with my words — to say what the logs actually prove and not more than that. Overall it gave me good practice at working an alert from start to finish: triage, investigation, a decision backed by evidence, and documentation that someone else can rely on.